English Week 5: the lonely school (written)

Ember · Real GCSE question, extract only · about 25 minutes Date: _____

Skill: Quote, effect, So What. Each paragraph: a short quote, the effect of a word or method, then what it shows about loneliness. Re-read the extract on screen (or below) before you start.

The extract (Chapter 2)

“The school is not quite deserted,” said the Ghost. “A solitary child, neglected by his friends, is left there still.” Scrooge said he knew it. And he sobbed. … It was a large house, but one of broken fortunes; for the spacious offices were little used, their walls were damp and mossy, their windows broken, and their gates decayed. … entering the dreary hall, and glancing through the open doors of many rooms, they found them poorly furnished, cold, and vast. There was an earthy savour in the air, a chilly bareness in the place, which associated itself somehow with too much getting up by candle-light, and not too much to eat. … It opened before them, and disclosed a long, bare, melancholy room, made barer still by lines of plain deal forms and desks. At one of these a lonely boy was reading near a feeble fire; and Scrooge sat down upon a form, and wept to see his poor forgotten self as he used to be. Not a latent echo in the house, not a squeak and scuffle from the mice behind the panelling, not a drip from the half-thawed water-spout in the dull yard behind, not a sigh among the leafless boughs of one despondent poplar, not the idle swinging of an empty store-house door, no, not a clicking in the fire, but fell upon the heart of Scrooge with a softening influence, and gave a freer passage to his tears.

Plan (5 min): one row per paragraph

Quote	Effect (word or method)	So What (loneliness)

AQA English Literature 8702/1N, June 2022, Q02 **[30 marks]**

Your version this week: write about the extract only, two or three paragraphs. (The full GCSE answer also covers the novel as a whole.)

Starting with this extract, explore how Dickens presents the effects of loneliness and isolation in *A Christmas Carol*.

Write about:
- **how Dickens presents the effects of loneliness and isolation in this extract**
- **how Dickens presents the effects of loneliness and isolation in the novel as a whole.**

Self-check (5 min)

□ Each paragraph has a short, exact quote.

□ Each paragraph explains the effect of one word or method.

□ Each paragraph ends with So What: what it shows about loneliness.

□ I used at least one method name (adjective, list, repetition, contrast) **and** said what it does.

□ Reflection: which So What was hardest to write? Where would you put yourself on the levels below?

AQA's levels (8702/1N mark scheme, AO2: the writer's methods)

- **Level 2** (supported, relevant comments): "Identification of writers' methods. Some reference to subject terminology."
- **Level 3** (explained, structured comments): "Explained/relevant comments on writer's methods with some relevant use of subject terminology. Identification of effects of writer's methods to create meanings."
- **Level 4** (clear understanding): "Clear explanation of writer's methods with appropriate use of relevant subject terminology. Understanding of effects of writer's methods to create meanings."

Naming "alliteration" with no effect = Level 2. Quote + effect = Level 3. Quote + effect + So What, every time = heading for Level 4.

AQA's indicative content for the extract (things answers might include)

- first vision introducing Scrooge as 'solitary'
- description of school as bleak, uncared for place
- use of cold imagery
- alliteration of 'feeble fire'
- ideas about effect of loneliness and isolation; ideas about the importance of love and compassion

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Extract from Charles Dickens, A Christmas Carol (1843, public domain), as set in AQA English Literature 8702/1N June 2022 Q02. Question and mark scheme wording © AQA, used for private practice.